



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

IN MALIBU, where burned homes and cars were caked in mud, a cascade of storm debris slammed into a Fire Department vehicle in the 19600 block of Pacific Coast Highway, pushing it down a cliff and into the Pacific Ocean. The driver escaped without significant injury.

Inside the ‘It Ends With Us’ legal brawl

Lively-Baldoni court battles display a dark side of Hollywood’s star-making machine



JOEL C RYAN Invision / AP
BLAKE LIVELY alleges in a suit that her co-star retaliated against her for reporting harassment.

BY STACY PERMAN

U.S. District Judge Lewis J. Liman had seen enough. After a continuous volley of highly charged accusations turned the legal battle between actors Blake Lively and Justin Baldoni into a public spectacle, Liman admonished the attorneys for both sides. He pointedly reminded them to abide by the New York rule that bars lawyers from making public comments outside the court that could prejudice the proceedings.

“You’ve got a lot in front of the court that gives ... the public plenty to feast upon,”

Liman said at a hearing held in federal district court in Manhattan last week. “There will come a time, unless this case is settled, that a jury will speak.”

For many, the extraordinary Lively-Baldoni saga has highlighted not only the dark arts of Hollywood publicity but also the role of high-profile celebrity attorneys and the increasingly aggressive tactics they use to defend their clients.

“It’s unbelievable,” said Neville Johnson, a veteran entertainment litigator. “It’s just clear the pleadings in this case have been intended for an audience beyond the court, namely the public,

and that’s what sets it apart from a traditional libel case or others of that nature.”

Aggressive legal tactics

Hollywood’s publicity machine has always been cutthroat. In the early days of the studio system, moguls helped seed negative (and flattering) stories about celebrities, both creating scandals and suppressing them.

The 1957 noir film “Sweet Smell of Success” features an unscrupulous press agent, said to be based on gossip columnist Walter Winchell, who took pleasure [See **Hollywood PR**, A8]



Associated Press
JUSTIN BALDONI has countersued Lively and taken drastic steps to defend himself in public.

Region’s cycle of drought to deluge returns

Pacific Coast Highway goes from smoldering to flooded as storm brings record rainfall.

BY RUBEN VIVES, HANNAH FRY AND KAREN GARCIA

Just five weeks ago, Pacific Coast Highway was smoldering from one of the most destructive firestorms in Los Angeles County history, with burned-out shells where scores of oceanside homes once stood.

On Friday, the storied coastal road had dissolved into a river of mud and debris after a powerful rainstorm sent those burned hillsides sliding toward the ocean, turning canyons into rivers of mud and rocks.

Southern California is used to the cycle of drought and deluge, where fires are followed by flooding and debris flows. But the last few weeks have brought particular climate whiplash to residents of the Pacific Palisades and Altadena burn zones. The fires exploded in part because of a lack of winter rain, which left the landscape unusually bone-dry for January. The rains finally came, but they brought a second wave of challenges. Damage from this week’s rains were negligible compared to the fires’ destruction.

“This was a one-two punch,” said Capt. Erik Scott, a spokesperson for the Los Angeles Fire Department. “There’s an abundance of hazardous materials that needs to be removed, followed by fire debris removal, quickly followed by rain and mud, debris flow — all within a month and a half.”

The aftermath of a powerful storm that dumped rain across Los Angeles County’s burn scars came into focus Friday, with a section of Pacific Coast Highway closed after a hill dissolved into a river of mud and rockslides blocking canyon roads that meander through the area’s foothills.

At the height of the storm, mudslides rushed [See **Cycle**, A5]

Police captain alleges wrongful force, union retaliation

Silvia Sanchez claims she has been targeted for scrutinizing teen’s arrest on the Eastside.

BY LIBOR JANY

The incident that put Los Angeles Police Capt. Silvia Sanchez on a collision course with the union that represents more than 8,000

rank-and-file cops began with a 911 call about a fight on the city’s Eastside.

Two Hollenbeck Division officers showed up to find two young women arguing in the street. They decided to arrest the younger one, a 16-year-old, on suspicion of domestic violence, detaining her without force — or so they wrote in their report.

A routine review found nothing amiss with their actions, and the case was all

but closed and forgotten. Then Sanchez, the Hollenbeck patrol captain, intervened.

After receiving a complaint about the March 30, 2022, incident, she went back and reviewed the officers’ body-worn camera footage. The video seemed to show one of the cops grabbing the teen by the neck and slamming her against a concrete barrier, Sanchez alleged.

Sanchez ordered an investigation into the officers’ “illegal detention followed by an unauthorized use of force” and their failure to document it, she said in a government claim she filed against the city in October.

Her moves have drawn the ire of the powerful Los Angeles Police Protective League. The veteran female commander and her allies allege she has become the target of a smear campaign

by union leadership to turn the department against her. The union’s president has accused Sanchez of going out of her way to railroad a pair of officers for doing their jobs.

The case has become the latest lightning rod in a long-running debate over how to reform the department’s disciplinary system. Amid numerous reports that have faulted the department for [See **LAPD**, A6]

Anxiety shadows residents of mobile homes in Palisades

BY HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS

There has been a sobering awareness in the WhatsApp group chat where Clove Galilee has kept up with her neighbors since the Palisades fire destroyed their homes.

It’s the realization that, one month after the crisis, “life has gone on for most people,” said Galilee, who lived with her wife in the Tahitian Terrace mobile home park in Pacific Palisades.

But not for them.

“It’s like a death in a family,” Galilee said. “Everyone’s like, ‘Oh, can I help you?’ for the first month. And then? Time goes on. And all of these people are still going to be struggling.”

For people who lived in Tahitian Terrace and the adjacent Palisades Bowl mobile home park, the struggle to figure out their lives after the fire has been compounded by a deep uncertainty about whether the parks — which contained [See **Mobile homes**, A10]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

CLOVE GALILEE, left, and wife Jenny Rogers pause on a walk outside a hotel in Marina del Rey, where they are living after their Palisades mobile home burned.

States sue over Musk’s power

Lawsuit denounces as unconstitutional tech billionaire’s assumed authority to slash U.S. agencies. **NATION**, A4

Activists stand up to ICE action

A coalition of immigrant rights groups in the Southland plans to inform community of raids. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Watkins leads USC past UCLA

Slumping Trojans star finds her shot to deliver a sensational game against the top-ranked Bruins. **SPORTS**, B12

Weather
Partial sunshine.
L.A. Basin: 67/51. **B8**

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